

FILE NAMING CONVENTION AND RECORDS QUALITY CONTROL PROCEDURE

Standard Operating Procedure — Litigation Records

Version 1.0 · Prepared by Peace Obisike

Sample prepared with invented facts. No client information.

1. Purpose

This procedure sets one consistent way to name, store, index and check every document that enters a litigation file. It exists so that any document can be found by any authorized person in under a minute, so that no document is lost, duplicated or filed to the wrong matter, and so that the firm can show on request when a record was checked and by whom.

2. Scope

This procedure applies to every document received into or produced for a client matter, in any format: paper scanned to PDF, email attachments, portal downloads, faxes, and documents the firm creates itself. It applies from the moment a document arrives until it is destroyed under the retention schedule.

3. Responsibility

Records custodian — names, indexes, stores and quality-checks each document, and maintains the document index and retrieval log.

Requesting fee earner — logs any document taken out of the file and returns or closes the request.

Supervising attorney — approves any new document type, any change to the retention schedule, and any decision to destroy a record.

4. The Naming Rule

Every file is named in four parts, separated by underscores:

YYYY-MM-DD_DocumentType_Source_DocID.pdf

Worked example: 2026-02-27_MedicalRecord_ScrippsMemorial_D-0003.pdf

4.1 Part one — the date

Use the date printed on the document, not the date it arrived. Always write it as year, then month, then day, with hyphens. Written this way, files sort themselves into date order automatically in every system. If a document carries no date, use the date of receipt and add the word Undated to the description column of the index.

4.2 Part two — the document type

Use one of the approved types in Appendix A. Spell it exactly as listed, with no spaces. If a document does not fit an approved type, do not invent one. Ask the supervising attorney to approve a new type, then add it to Appendix A so it is available for everyone.

4.3 Part three — the source

Name who produced the document. Remove spaces and punctuation by joining the words together, for example ScrippsMemorial or CoastlinePT. For documents the firm produces, use the word Outgoing followed by a short description, for example OutgoingLOR or OutgoingRecordsRequest.

4.4 Part four — the document ID

Take the next unused ID from the document index, written as D- followed by four digits. An ID is assigned once and never reused, even if the document is later superseded or removed from the active file.

5. What Is Never Allowed

- Spaces or punctuation in file names, other than the underscore separators and the hyphens in the date. Characters such as & / # % , and apostrophes break links and cloud syncing.
- Names that describe nothing: final.pdf, scan1.pdf, new version.pdf, Untitled.pdf, or a client name on its own.
- Two files with the same name anywhere in the matter folder.
- Saving a document anywhere other than the folder set for its type.
- Overwriting an existing file. A replacement document gets its own ID; the earlier version moves to the superseded folder.
- Storing a working copy only on a local machine. Every filed record must exist in the firm's cloud storage.

6. Folder Structure

Each matter folder is named MatterName_MatterNumber and contains the same twelve subfolders, in this order, so that every matter looks identical:

01_Incident · 02_Engagement · 03_Medical/Records · 03_Medical/Bills · 04_Correspondence ·
05_Insurance · 06_Damages · 07_Pleadings · 08_Discovery · 09_Experts · 10_Internal · 99_Superseded

7. Intake Workflow

Follow these steps in order every time a document arrives.

- Step 1. Confirm the document belongs to the matter. Check the client name and the date of incident against the matter record. If it does not match, stop and report it the same day. Do not file it.
- Step 2. Check the document is complete and readable. Count the pages. Look for cut-off text, black bars, blank pages and pages scanned sideways or upside down.
- Step 3. Run optical character recognition on any scanned document so the text is searchable.
- Step 4. Assign the next document ID from the index.
- Step 5. Rename the file under the naming rule in section 4.
- Step 6. Save it to the correct subfolder.
- Step 7. Complete the index row in full: dates, type, description, source, page count, Bates range, file name, storage path, confidentiality flag and retention date.
- Step 8. Set the status to Pending QC.
- Step 9. Run the quality control checklist in section 8. When every line passes, enter your initials and the date, and change the status to Filed.

8. Quality Control

A document is not filed until every line below passes. One failed line means the status stays at Pending QC until it is fixed.

- All pages present and in order, and the page count matches the index.
- Every page readable, right way up, nothing cut off.

- Correct matter confirmed against client name and date of incident.
- File name follows the naming rule exactly.
- Saved in the correct subfolder.
- Index row complete, with no blank cells.
- Date entered is the date on the document, not the date of receipt.
- Not a duplicate of a document already indexed.
- Any version it replaces has been moved to the superseded folder.
- Optical character recognition has been run on scans.
- Confidentiality flag set. Anything containing medical or financial content is flagged.
- Retention date calculated from the retention schedule.
- Bates range does not overlap a range already used in the matter.
- A backup copy exists in cloud storage.

9. Retrieval

Nothing leaves the file without a row in the retrieval log recording the date, the document ID, who asked for it, why, and whether it has been returned. A request still outstanding after five business days is chased in writing. Where a copy can serve the purpose, issue the copy and keep the original in the file.

10. Confidentiality and Access

Access is granted by role, not by request. A person is given access to a matter folder only where the work they do requires it, and that access is removed when the work ends. Documents flagged confidential are stored in folders with restricted permissions. Client documents are never sent to personal email accounts, never stored on personal devices without encryption, and never opened over public wireless networks without a secure connection. A suspected disclosure is reported the same day; a delay makes it worse in every case.

11. Corrections and Errors

Index entries are corrected, never erased. Where a correction is made after a record has been marked filed, note what changed, who changed it and when, in the notes column. Where an error may have affected a filing deadline, a production or a document served on another party, report it to the supervising attorney immediately rather than correcting it quietly.

12. Retention

Retention periods are set by the firm's own retention schedule and by any applicable statute and rule of professional conduct. The indicative periods used in the accompanying sample are seven years from close of matter for a general litigation file, and ten years for records containing protected health information. These are placeholders for the purpose of the sample and must be replaced with the firm's actual schedule before use. No record is destroyed without written authorization from the supervising attorney.

Appendix A — Approved Document Types

- Incident Report — police reports, collision reports, scene documentation
- Retainer Agreement — fee agreements, engagement letters, scope amendments
- Medical Record — clinical notes, imaging reports, hospital records, therapy notes

- Medical Bill — itemized statements, billing ledgers, liens, explanations of benefits
- Correspondence — letters and formal emails, incoming and outgoing
- Insurance Document — policies, claim acknowledgments, coverage letters, adjuster correspondence
- Employment Record — wage records, time records, employer statements
- Pleading — complaints, answers, motions, orders, notices
- Discovery — interrogatories, requests for production, responses, deposition transcripts
- Authorization — HIPAA authorizations, records release forms, signed consents
- Expert Material — expert reports, curricula vitae, retention letters
- Internal Note — case memos, call notes, internal summaries

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